

Area of Study 1B – Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Christianity as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically within families, and with regard to matters of life and death.

There are four sections: Christian Beliefs, Marriage and the Family, Living the Christian Life and Matters of Life and Death.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Christians today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how the Bible informs a Christian's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should recognise that Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity with one of either Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, or Sikhism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.6)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.1)*

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Christianity with non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Christianity in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually, including reference to Matthew 3:13–17; how this is reflected in Christian worship and belief today.
1.2	The creation of the universe and of humanity: the biblical account of creation and divergent ways in which it may be understood by Christians, including as literal and metaphorical; the role of the Word and Spirit in creation, including John 1:1–18 and Genesis 1–3; the importance of creation for Christians today.
1.3	The Incarnation: the nature and importance of the person of Jesus Christ as the incarnate Son of God; the biblical basis of this teaching, including John 1:1–18 and 1 Timothy 3:16 and its significance for Christians today.
1.4	The last days of Jesus' life: the Last Supper, betrayal, arrest, trial, crucifixion, resurrection and ascension of Jesus; the accounts of these within the Bible, including Luke 22–24 and the significance of these events to understanding the person of Jesus Christ.
1.5	The nature and significance of salvation and the role of Christ within salvation: law, sin, grace and Spirit, the role of Christ in salvation, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the nature and significance of atonement within Christianity and its link to salvation.
1.6*	Christian eschatology: divergent Christian teachings about life after death, including the nature and significance of resurrection, judgement, heaven, and hell and purgatory, with reference to the 39 Articles of Religion and Catholic teachings; how beliefs about life after death are shown in the Bible, including reference to 2 Corinthians 5:1–10 and divergent understandings as to why they are important for Christians today.
1.7	The problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: the problems it raises for Christians about the nature of God, including reference to omnipotence and benevolence, including Psalm 103; how the problem may cause believers to question their faith or the existence of God; the nature and examples of natural suffering, moral suffering.
1.8	Divergent solutions offered to the problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: biblical, theoretical and practical, including reference to Psalm 119, Job, free will, vale of soul-making, prayer, and charity; the success of solutions to the problem.